

People

Aboriginal people, Australia's first inhabitants, make up only about four per cent of the population. The rest are of mainly European origin, descended either from British settlers, or from Europeans who emigrated to Australia after 1945. Recent years have also seen an influx of Asians.



2 per sq km
(5 per sq mile)



85% Urban
15% Rural



Multicultural society

Australian society reflects the many different nationalities who have settled in the country. Aboriginal people, English, Irish, and Central and Eastern Europeans have all made their mark, and since immigration restrictions were lifted in 1972 the arrival of Chinese, Indo-Chinese, and Indonesians has added new influences. Diverse languages, customs, foods, and festivals combine to make Australia a varied and exciting society.

Farming

Less than five per cent of the labour force are farmers, yet over half the land is used for grazing cattle and sheep. Grapes and cereals are also grown.



Livestock

Beef cattle roam the Australian outback, grazing on dry grass and drinking water drawn from artesian wells. They are raised on vast cattle stations mainly for their meat. Australia has seven times more sheep than people. They produce around one-third of the world's wool.

Grapes

The gentle climate of parts of southern Australia is ideally suited to growing grapes for winemaking. The Australian wine industry has grown by leaps and bounds in recent years, now producing about 450,000 tonnes (495,000 tons) of wine a year. Much is exported.



Cereals

Although less than four per cent of the land is suitable for farming cereal crops, Australia grows barley, millet, oats, and rice, and ranks highly in world production of wheat. Other crops include sugar-cane, fruit, and vegetables.



Industry

Australia has a strong mining industry, and is a major exporter of coal, iron ore, bauxite, lead, gold, copper, and diamonds. About 16 per cent of the labour force works in manufacturing, and two-thirds are employed in services such as banks, tourism, and government.

Gold and diamonds

Australia is one of the world's top gold producers and exports more diamonds than any other country. Most of the diamonds are not gem quality and are used to make industrial cutting tools.

Diamonds



Gold



Quartz



Tourism

The spectacular scenery of the Hamersley Range in Western Australia is popular with tourists, mostly from Japan, New Zealand, and Southeast Asia. About five million visitors visit Australia every year, providing a welcome addition to the country's foreign earnings.

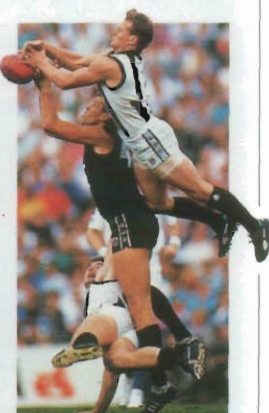
Leisure

Australians love the outdoors. Because most live near the coast, many people enjoy water sports such as swimming, skin-diving, surfing, and sailing. Cricket is a popular spectator sport, as are rugby and the unique Australian Football.



Surfing

The crashing waves of Australia's east coast attract thousands to try their luck at riding the surf. The aptly named Surfers' Paradise, in Queensland, is a favourite spot.



Australian Football

One of Australia's national winter sports is Australian Football. It was invented in the 1850s and is based on Gaelic Football. Besides Australia, the only other country where it is played is Papua New Guinea.

Food

Traditionally, Australians are a nation of meat-eaters. They love plain foods, such as fried eggs and grilled steaks that are cooked on the barbecue. But the influx of people from mainland Europe and Asia has brought a wide range of cooking ideas from China, Greece, Indonesia, and Italy.

Barbecued lamb

Grilled pumpkin



Transport

With such a huge territory, and the nearest countries so far away from major population centres, Australians rely heavily on air transport. Buses, cars, and trains are used for short distances in the cities. Trucks carry most intercity freight by road.



Road train

Heavy loads are often transported across the outback by road train. These huge trucks may pull five or six trailers over vast distances, on deserted roads.

Flying Doctor

The Royal Flying Doctor Service was founded in 1928 to bring medical help to people living in lonely homesteads in the outback. Doctors are based at special stations where emergency callers can contact them by radio and receive treatment quickly.

